

SITE OF SORROW
Wreckage of the Air India Boeing 787 Dreamliner in Ahmedabad

ANI

▶ GUJARAT

WHERE MEMORY CRASHED

On the eve of the Flight 171 crash report, the site is set to vanish—and kin are being asked to forget and forgive. A legal amnesia

By **Jumana Shah**

ON JUNE 12, 2025, THE WORLD HAD WATCHED multiple visuals of it—from multiple angles of horror. Flight 171 had slipped in the air, 32 seconds after liftoff from Ahmedabad airport, and coasted down almost gently for what would be the deadliest disaster in India's aviation history. The register of the dead had 260 names. Exactly a year later, there comes an angle no one had foreseen. The families of the victims are fighting to preserve two pieces of turf: the physical site where their people fell, and the ground of justice. It's still unknown why the plane crashed, but they are being told to sign away their legal futures.

The first anniversary is upon us of the day Air India's London-bound Boeing 787-8 Dreamliner, with 242 people on board, crashed at the BJ Medical College hostel complex in Meghaninagar. But it's a complex pain the families feel. The probe has not concluded, yet the Gujarat government has announced a Rs 105-crore redevelopment plan at the site—part of the evidence pool. A structural audit deemed the old buildings unsafe, demolition unavoidable. So a new G+8 hostel complex will rise in its place: studio apartments for 236 students, landscaped spaces,